

STAGE TWELVE • LEADERSHIP

FIRSTS

FACILITATOR GUIDE

Learning objectives, talking points, and misconceptions to preempt for all 30 FIRSTS

A Citrus Edition Facilitator Resource • Companion to the FIRSTS Manual

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FIRSTS • Facilitator Guide

Stage Twelve • Leadership

HOW TO USE THIS GUIDE

This guide is for whoever is facilitating Stage Twelve, live or on video, individually or in a cohort. It sits alongside the FIRSTS Manual and Templates workbook — it does not replace them.

Stage Twelve covers thirty FIRSTS across three sections: Leadership Foundations, Leading & Developing People, and Advanced & Reflective Leadership. Each FIRST below gets a Learning Objective, Key Talking Points, and Common Misconceptions to Preempt.

This stage draws directly on nearly everything built in earlier stages — communication, teamwork, project management, business acumen. Expect participants with genuine prior leadership experience (a job, a club, a team) to have real material to work with, and participants without much yet to lean more heavily on observation and reflection. Both are valid starting points.

SESSION 1

Leadership Foundations

Covers *FIRSTS P1-P10*

FIRST P1

Leadership Awareness

LEARNING OBJECTIVE

Participants can articulate a clear, specific distinction between authority and genuine leadership, backed by real examples.

KEY TALKING POINTS

- Many people conflate leadership with title or authority, which produces a narrow, incomplete view of what actually makes someone effective.
- Genuine leadership is earned through trust and demonstrated judgment, not granted by an org chart.
- This distinction is the foundation for every other leadership FIRST in this stage.

COMMON MISCONCEPTIONS TO PREEMPT

- Assuming a title or position automatically confers leadership.
 - Believing leadership is a fixed trait rather than a demonstrated pattern of trust and judgment.
-

SUGGESTED TIME: 15 min

FIRST P2

Leadership Style Assessment

LEARNING OBJECTIVE

Participants name a specific natural leadership tendency and a specific area they genuinely want to develop.

KEY TALKING POINTS

- Understanding natural tendencies, both strengths and blind spots, lets you lead more deliberately rather than defaulting unconsciously.
- Self-perception alone is often inaccurate — real leadership tendencies are best checked against how others have actually experienced you.
- This assessment should feed directly into how participants approach the rest of this stage, not stand alone.

COMMON MISCONCEPTIONS TO PREEMPT

- Assuming your self-perception is accurate without ever checking it against how others have actually experienced your leadership.
 - Treating a single assessment result as a fixed, permanent leadership identity.
-

SUGGESTED TIME: 20 min

FIRST P3

Leadership Responsibility

LEARNING OBJECTIVE

Participants identify a real outcome they will explicitly take ownership of, including following through when it gets difficult.

KEY TALKING POINTS

- Genuine ownership, being accountable for the outcome even when things don't go perfectly, is a distinct and necessary step before anyone trusts you with formal leadership.
- Contributing effort is not the same as genuinely accepting accountability for how something turns out.
- This is the foundation for the Leadership Role FIRST that follows.

COMMON MISCONCEPTIONS TO PREEMPT

- Contributing effort to a project without ever genuinely accepting accountability for the outcome.
- Treating ownership as a title to claim rather than a genuine commitment to follow through.

SUGGESTED TIME: 15 min

FIRST P4

Leadership Role

LEARNING OBJECTIVE

Participants identify one upcoming opportunity to formally lead a group or initiative and commit to taking it on.

KEY TALKING POINTS

- Formal leadership roles provide genuine experience navigating specific challenges that observation and responsibility alone can't fully prepare you for.
- Continuing to avoid formal leadership indefinitely means missing real growth that only comes from actually holding a role.
- This directly extends Leadership Responsibility into a real, sustained position.

COMMON MISCONCEPTIONS TO PREEMPT

- Waiting to feel fully ready before taking on any formal leadership role.
- Assuming a leadership role requires a large, high-visibility context rather than any genuine opportunity to lead.

SUGGESTED TIME: 15 min

FIRST P5

Meeting Led

LEARNING OBJECTIVE

Participants plan a real meeting they will organize and lead, using a clear agenda and closing with explicit next steps.

KEY TALKING POINTS

- Leading a meeting well, not just attending it, is a distinct, learnable skill that directly signals leadership capability.
- An agenda prepared but not actually used to guide the meeting is a common, easily avoidable failure.
- This directly extends the Meeting Agenda Prepared and Discussion Facilitation skills from earlier stages.

COMMON MISCONCEPTIONS TO PREEMPT

- Preparing an agenda but not actually using it to guide the meeting.
- Ending a meeting without explicit next steps, assuming everyone already knows what happens next.

SUGGESTED TIME: 20 min

FIRST P6

Team Goal Set

LEARNING OBJECTIVE

Participants propose an explicit, specific team goal and plan how they'll confirm shared understanding.

KEY TALKING POINTS

- A team without a clear, explicit goal tends to drift, with members quietly pursuing their own interpretation of success.
- Assuming a shared goal is obvious from context is a common, costly mistake.
- Confirmation matters as much as the initial statement — can every team member restate the goal in their own words?

COMMON MISCONCEPTIONS TO PREEMPT

- Assuming a shared goal is obvious from context without ever stating it explicitly.
- Treating a single announcement of the goal as sufficient, without confirming genuine understanding.

SUGGESTED TIME: 15 min

FIRST P7

Vision Communicated

LEARNING OBJECTIVE

Participants articulate a real vision (not just a task list) for a current initiative and plan how to communicate it.

KEY TALKING POINTS

- A compelling vision, not just a task list, genuinely motivates a team beyond mere compliance.
- Communicating only the tasks involved, without articulating why the outcome matters, produces compliance rather than real engagement.

- This directly extends persuasive communication skills from earlier stages into a leadership context.

COMMON MISCONCEPTIONS TO PREEMPT

- Communicating only the tasks involved without ever articulating why the outcome genuinely matters.
- Assuming a vision only needs to be stated once, rather than reinforced throughout a project.

SUGGESTED TIME: 20 min

FIRST P8

Task Delegation

LEARNING OBJECTIVE

Participants assign a real task based explicitly on a team member's growth goal, not just their existing comfort.

KEY TALKING POINTS

- Delegation done well, based on genuine fit rather than convenience, both produces better work and develops team members' capabilities.
- Delegating purely based on who's already comfortable with a task misses real development opportunities.
- This extends earlier task delegation practice into a leadership-level accountability for the outcome.

COMMON MISCONCEPTIONS TO PREEMPT

- Delegating purely based on who's already comfortable with a task.
- Assuming delegation is only about distributing workload rather than also developing people.

SUGGESTED TIME: 20 min

FIRST P9

Accountability System Created

LEARNING OBJECTIVE

Participants set up a visible tracking system for their team's commitments and commit to reviewing it consistently.

KEY TALKING POINTS

- Without a genuine tracking system, commitments made in meetings tend to quietly slip.
- A leader needs real visibility into what's on track versus falling behind, not just an assumption that things are fine.
- Setting up a system once but never reviewing it is a common, easily avoidable failure.

COMMON MISCONCEPTIONS TO PREEMPT

- Setting up a tracking system once but never actually reviewing it consistently.
- Assuming a system alone (without genuine review) will catch problems automatically.

SUGGESTED TIME: 15 min

FIRST P10

Leadership Decision Made

LEARNING OBJECTIVE

Participants identify one current decision they've been avoiding as a leader and commit to making and communicating it.

KEY TALKING POINTS

- Leadership decisions carry weight beyond individual choices — genuinely owning a decision that affects others is a distinct responsibility.
- Avoiding or indefinitely delaying a decision out of fear of getting it wrong often costs the team more than a reasonably-timed imperfect decision.
- This closes the section by turning goal-setting, vision, delegation, and accountability into real decision-making.

COMMON MISCONCEPTIONS TO PREEMPT

- Avoiding or indefinitely delaying a genuine leadership decision out of fear of getting it wrong.
- Making a decision without communicating the reasoning behind it to those affected.

SUGGESTED TIME: 20 min

SESSION 2

Leading & Developing People

Covers *FIRSTS P11-P20*

FIRST P11

Difficult Decision Made

LEARNING OBJECTIVE

Participants work through their most difficult current leadership decision using explicit criteria rather than avoiding it.

KEY TALKING POINTS

- Easy decisions don't build much genuine leadership judgment; navigating real uncertainty is where leadership capability actually develops.
- Pretending a genuinely difficult decision was obvious avoids the real work of acknowledging its difficulty while still making a clear call.
- This directly extends Leadership Decision Made from Section 1 into genuinely harder territory.

COMMON MISCONCEPTIONS TO PREEMPT

- Pretending a genuinely difficult decision was obvious or easy.
 - Avoiding the decision entirely because every option involves some real cost.
-

SUGGESTED TIME: 20 min

FIRST P12

Leadership Communication

LEARNING OBJECTIVE

Participants plan to explicitly confirm their team's understanding of an expectation rather than assuming it.

KEY TALKING POINTS

- Unclear expectations from a leader are one of the most common sources of team friction and dropped responsibilities.
- Assuming expectations are understood simply because they were mentioned once is a common, avoidable mistake.
- Confirming understanding explicitly, not just stating it once, is what actually prevents downstream confusion.

COMMON MISCONCEPTIONS TO PREEMPT

- Assuming expectations are understood simply because they were mentioned once.
 - Confusing having communicated something with having confirmed it was actually understood.
-

SUGGESTED TIME: 15 min

FIRST P13

Team Motivation Exercise

LEARNING OBJECTIVE

Participants identify a real dip in team energy and plan one specific action to address it.

KEY TALKING POINTS

- Motivation isn't a single speech; sustaining genuine engagement over time requires ongoing, deliberate attention.
- Assuming motivation only matters at a project's kickoff misses the ongoing attention needed through difficult stretches.
- Specific, timely action matters more than generic encouragement.

COMMON MISCONCEPTIONS TO PREEMPT

- Assuming motivation only matters at a project's kickoff.
 - Responding to flagging energy with generic encouragement rather than a specific, genuine action.
-

SUGGESTED TIME: 15 min

FIRST P14

Person Mentored

LEARNING OBJECTIVE

Participants identify one person they could genuinely mentor in a specific skill and commit to helping them develop it over time.

KEY TALKING POINTS

- Mentoring someone else's development is a distinct leadership skill from doing the work yourself.
- Doing the task for the person you're mentoring, rather than developing their own capability, undercuts the entire point.
- This is a sustained relationship, not a single conversation — set that expectation clearly.

COMMON MISCONCEPTIONS TO PREEMPT

- Doing the task for the person you're mentoring instead of developing their own capability.
 - Treating mentorship as a single piece of advice rather than an ongoing relationship.
-

SUGGESTED TIME: 15 min

FIRST P15

Person Coached

LEARNING OBJECTIVE

Participants practice coaching someone toward their own solution using guiding questions instead of providing the answer.

KEY TALKING POINTS

- Coaching builds genuine independent problem-solving capability in a way that simply providing answers doesn't.
- Slipping into mentoring or directly answering the problem undercuts coaching's real value.
- This is a genuinely distinct skill from mentoring — worth explicitly contrasting the two.

COMMON MISCONCEPTIONS TO PREEMPT

- Slipping into mentoring or directly answering the problem rather than asking guiding questions.
- Assuming coaching means being passive rather than actively guiding through questions.

SUGGESTED TIME: 20 min

FIRST P16

Constructive Feedback Given as a Leader

LEARNING OBJECTIVE

Participants deliver one piece of constructive feedback to someone they lead, framed around genuine growth.

KEY TALKING POINTS

- Feedback from a leader carries particular weight — delivering it constructively while keeping the person motivated matters more here than in peer feedback.
- Softening feedback so much the improvement area gets lost is as much a failure as delivering it too bluntly.
- Framing feedback around genuine growth, not just correction, changes how it lands.

COMMON MISCONCEPTIONS TO PREEMPT

- Softening feedback so much that the actual improvement area gets lost.
- Delivering feedback so bluntly that it discourages rather than motivates.

SUGGESTED TIME: 20 min

FIRST P17

Difficult Feedback Conversation

LEARNING OBJECTIVE

Participants identify one difficult feedback conversation they've been avoiding and prepare specifically what they'll say.

KEY TALKING POINTS

- Not all feedback conversations are comfortable; addressing a genuinely difficult issue directly is a critical leadership skill.
- Avoiding a necessary difficult conversation indefinitely usually makes the underlying issue worse and erodes trust.
- Preparation in advance, not improvisation, is what makes a hard conversation actually manageable.

COMMON MISCONCEPTIONS TO PREEMPT

- Avoiding a genuinely necessary difficult conversation indefinitely.
- Assuming preparation isn't needed because the conversation feels obvious in your own head.

SUGGESTED TIME: 20 min

FIRST P18

Conflict Handled as a Leader

LEARNING OBJECTIVE

Participants identify a genuine team conflict and plan to address it directly rather than hoping it resolves on its own.

KEY TALKING POINTS

- As a leader, conflict resolution isn't optional — unresolved team conflict directly undermines the team's ability to deliver.
- Avoiding team conflict out of discomfort is a genuine abdication of leadership responsibility.
- Resolution should preserve, not just end, the team's working effectiveness.

COMMON MISCONCEPTIONS TO PREEMPT

- Avoiding team conflict out of discomfort, hoping it resolves on its own.
- Treating conflict resolution as optional rather than a core leadership responsibility.

SUGGESTED TIME: 20 min

FIRST P19

Team Performance Review

LEARNING OBJECTIVE

Participants conduct a real performance review comparing actual progress against original goals.

KEY TALKING POINTS

- Regular, honest performance evaluation is what lets a leader course-correct before small issues become significant.
- Skipping honest evaluation until the very end leaves no time to actually fix anything.
- This directly uses the Team Goal Set FIRST from Section 1 as the basis for comparison.

COMMON MISCONCEPTIONS TO PREEMPT

- Skipping honest performance evaluation until a project's very end.
- Conducting a review that avoids naming real gaps to preserve team morale in the short term.

SUGGESTED TIME: 15 min

FIRST P20

Leadership Presentation

LEARNING OBJECTIVE

Participants practice presenting a real recommendation with clear, owned conviction rather than excessive hedging.

KEY TALKING POINTS

- Presenting as a leader carries distinct weight — the audience evaluates both the idea and your judgment and credibility.
- Hedging excessively to seem open-minded can undermine genuine confidence in your leadership and the recommendation itself.
- This closes the section by combining communication, decision-making, and feedback into one visible moment.

COMMON MISCONCEPTIONS TO PREEMPT

- Hedging excessively out of a desire to seem open-minded.
- Confusing genuine openness to feedback with a lack of clear conviction in the recommendation itself.

SUGGESTED TIME: *20 min*

SESSION 3

Advanced & Reflective Leadership

Covers *FIRSTS P21-P30*

FIRST P21

Cross-Functional Leadership Experience

LEARNING OBJECTIVE

Participants identify one way to translate their communication for a different function's priorities.

KEY TALKING POINTS

- Leading across functional boundaries requires translating between different disciplines' priorities and vocabularies.
- Leading a cross-functional team the same way you'd lead within your own function misses genuine translation work.
- This is a distinct, valuable leadership skill beyond leading within a single function.

COMMON MISCONCEPTIONS TO PREEMPT

- Leading a cross-functional team the same way you'd lead a team within your own function.
 - Assuming other functions share your own priorities and vocabulary by default.
-

SUGGESTED TIME: 20 min

FIRST P22

Leadership Without Authority

LEARNING OBJECTIVE

Participants identify one person they need to influence without formal authority and frame a request around a genuinely shared goal.

KEY TALKING POINTS

- Most real influence in a career happens without formal authority — this skill often matters more than authority-based leadership.
- Attempting to influence through demands or pressure without formal authority tends to backfire.
- Framing requests around genuinely shared goals, not personal authority, is what actually works.

COMMON MISCONCEPTIONS TO PREEMPT

- Attempting to influence through demands or pressure when you lack formal authority.
 - Assuming influence without authority is impossible rather than a genuinely learnable skill.
-

SUGGESTED TIME: 20 min

FIRST P23

Stakeholder Influence Exercise

LEARNING OBJECTIVE

Participants identify the specific priorities of two different stakeholders and tailor their pitch to each.

KEY TALKING POINTS

- Genuine stakeholder influence means understanding what each stakeholder actually cares about, not using one generic pitch.
- Using the exact same pitch for every stakeholder misses the chance to address specific concerns.
- This directly extends Leadership Without Authority into a more structured, deliberate practice.

COMMON MISCONCEPTIONS TO PREEMPT

- Using the exact same pitch for every stakeholder.
- Assuming all stakeholders share the same priorities or concerns.

SUGGESTED TIME: 20 min

FIRST P24

Crisis Leadership Exercise

LEARNING OBJECTIVE

Participants reflect on a past unexpected challenge and identify one way they could have provided clearer direction.

KEY TALKING POINTS

- How a leader responds to an unexpected crisis, calm and directive versus panicked, significantly shapes how the team responds.
- Freezing under pressure or overreacting both spread the wrong signal through a team.
- This is inherently situational — reflection on a real past moment is the most available practice.

COMMON MISCONCEPTIONS TO PREEMPT

- Freezing under the pressure of a genuine crisis.
- Overreacting in a way that spreads panic through the team rather than calm, clear direction.

SUGGESTED TIME: 20 min

FIRST P25

Leadership Under Pressure

LEARNING OBJECTIVE

Participants name their current highest-pressure leadership situation and one stress management technique they'll deliberately use.

KEY TALKING POINTS

- Sustained high-pressure periods test leadership judgment differently than a single acute crisis, requiring sustained composure.
- Letting sustained pressure erode judgment over time can undo good handling of an initial crisis moment.
- This directly extends Crisis Leadership Exercise and stress management practice from earlier stages.

COMMON MISCONCEPTIONS TO PREEMPT

- Letting sustained pressure erode your judgment or professionalism over time.
- Assuming handling one crisis moment well means sustained pressure is automatically manageable too.

SUGGESTED TIME: 15 min

FIRST P26

Strategic Leadership Exercise

LEARNING OBJECTIVE

Participants map their team's current activities against a broader strategic goal and flag any genuine gap.

KEY TALKING POINTS

- A leader who only manages immediate tasks risks leading a team efficiently toward the wrong destination.
- Staying purely tactical without connecting to broader strategy is a common, costly blind spot.
- This exercise should surface at least one real, previously unnoticed disconnect.

COMMON MISCONCEPTIONS TO PREEMPT

- Staying purely tactical, managing immediate tasks well without connecting them to broader strategic goals.
- Assuming strategic alignment is someone else's job rather than an active leadership responsibility.

SUGGESTED TIME: 20 min

FIRST P27

Leadership Feedback Received

LEARNING OBJECTIVE

Participants plan to ask their team for specific, honest feedback about their leadership.

KEY TALKING POINTS

- Leaders often receive less honest feedback than they think, since people hesitate to critique someone with authority over them.
- Only asking for feedback in a setting where people don't feel safe produces artificially positive, unhelpful responses.
- Actively, genuinely seeking honest feedback is necessary to counter this dynamic.

COMMON MISCONCEPTIONS TO PREEMPT

- Only asking for feedback in a setting where people don't feel safe being genuinely honest.
- Assuming the absence of complaints means leadership is going well.

SUGGESTED TIME: 15 min

FIRST P28

Leadership Mistake Reflection

LEARNING OBJECTIVE

Participants reflect honestly on a genuine leadership mistake and identify a specific, concrete change for next time.

KEY TALKING POINTS

- Every leader makes real mistakes; genuine growth comes from honestly analyzing them rather than deflecting.
- Deflecting blame onto others or circumstances avoids the real, useful work of this reflection.
- A specific, concrete change matters more than a vague resolution to “do better.”

COMMON MISCONCEPTIONS TO PREEMPT

- Deflecting blame onto others or circumstances rather than honestly owning your own role.
- Treating reflection as an apology rather than an actual, concrete plan to change.

SUGGESTED TIME: 20 min

FIRST P29

Leadership Philosophy

LEARNING OBJECTIVE

Participants write a two-to-three-sentence leadership philosophy based on their genuine leadership experiences throughout this stage.

KEY TALKING POINTS

- A clear, genuine leadership philosophy helps you lead consistently according to your own real principles.
- Writing a philosophy that sounds impressive but doesn't reflect real experience misses the point entirely.
- This should draw directly on real moments from this stage, not abstract ideals.

COMMON MISCONCEPTIONS TO PREEMPT

- Writing a leadership philosophy that sounds impressive but doesn't actually reflect how you've genuinely led.
- Treating this as a one-time writing exercise rather than something to actually reference later.

SUGGESTED TIME: 20 min

FIRST P30

Leadership Development Plan

LEARNING OBJECTIVE

Participants choose their top priority leadership growth area and outline three specific milestones for the next quarter.

KEY TALKING POINTS

- A specific, time-bound development plan turns leadership growth from a vague aspiration into a genuine, trackable practice.
- Setting a plan too broad or unfocused undermines genuine prioritization of what actually needs work.
- This closes the stage by combining every reflection and assessment from Sections 1 through 3 into one forward-looking commitment.

COMMON MISCONCEPTIONS TO PREEMPT

- Setting a plan too broad or unfocused, rather than genuinely prioritizing.
- Treating this as a final assignment rather than a living plan to actually revisit.

SUGGESTED TIME: *20 min*